

THE SEASON, IN FIVE-DAY WEEKS

Daikan — 大寒

Winter's last and coldest *sekk*i, late January. The court astronomer Shibukawa Shunkai rewrote these names in 1685 so they would match the Japanese sky rather than the Chinese one they were borrowed from. Read across its three *kō* and you can feel the year leaning toward spring.

First kō Butterbuds bud beneath the snow. The first green thought of the year, made underground, in the dark, where no one asked it to.

Second kō Mountain streams freeze solid. The pause — the held note. The week to do less, not more.

Third kō Hens begin to lay. The turn. *Risshun*, the beginning of spring, is now five days away — by the old reckoning, not the thermometer's.

